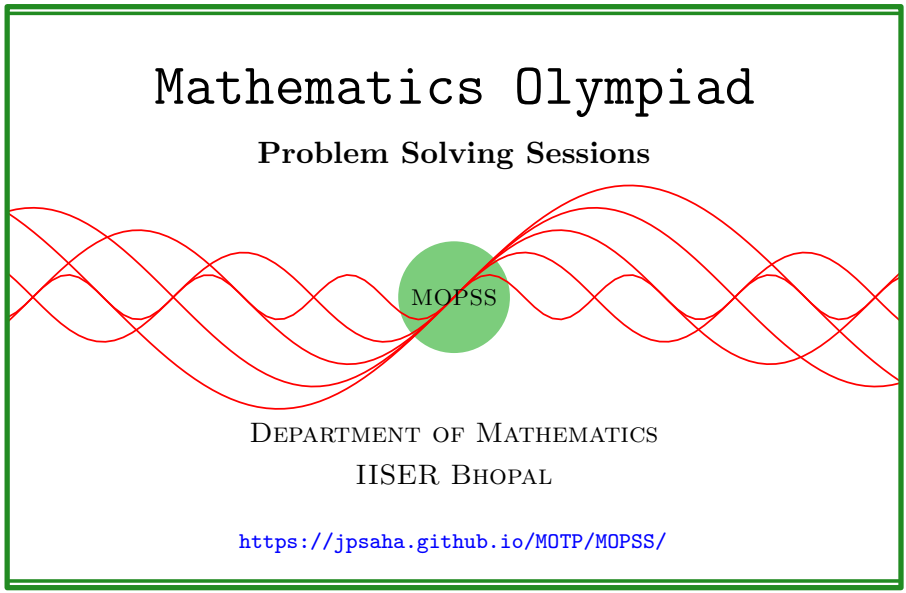
Rational and irrational numbers



Suggested readings

- Evan Chen's advice On reading solutions, available at https://blog.evanchen.cc/2017/03/06/on-reading-solutions/.
- Evan Chen's Advice for writing proofs/Remarks on English, available at https://web.evanchen.cc/handouts/english/english.pdf.
- Notes on proofs by Evan Chen from OTIS Excerpts [**Che25**, Chapter 1].
- Tips for writing up solutions by Edward Barbeau, available at https://www.math.utoronto.ca/barbeau/writingup.pdf.
- Evan Chen discusses why math olympiads are a valuable experience for high schoolers in the post on Lessons from math olympiads, available at https://blog.evanchen.cc/2018/01/05/lessons-from-math-olympiads/.

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§1 Rational and irrational numbers

Exercise 1 (IMOSL 2006 N2, , proposed by J. P. Grossman, Canada,). For $x \in (0,1)$, let $y \in (0,1)$ be the number whose n-th digit after the decimal point is the 2^n-th digit after the decimal point of x. Show that if x is rational then so is y.

Walkthrough —

(a) Assume that x is a rational number. Let k be the period of the decimal expansion of x.

(b) To show that y is rational, or equivalently, to show that the decimal expansion of y is eventually periodic, it suffices to prove that there exists a positive integer α such that

$$2^{n+\alpha} \equiv 2^n \pmod{k}$$

holds for all sufficiently large positive integers n.

Exercise 2 (Danube Mathematical Competition, Junior 2019 P2,). Prove that for any real numbers $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n$ with $n \in \mathbb{N}$, there exists a real number x such that the numbers $x + a_1, x + a_2, \ldots, x + a_n$ are all irrational.

Walkthrough —

(a) Under what condition on x, it is false that all of the numbers $x + a_1, x + a_2, \ldots, x + a_n$ are irrational?

(b) What can be said about the set of real numbers x such that at least one of the numbers $x + a_1, x + a_2, \ldots, x + a_n$ is rational?

Solution 1. For any $1 \leq i \leq n$, note that the set of real numbers x such that $x + a_i$ is rational is countable, since it is the set of real numbers of the form $r - a_i$ for some rational number r. Since the union of countably many countable sets is countable, the set of real numbers x such that at least one of the numbers $x + a_1, x + a_2, \ldots, x + a_n$ is rational is countable. Since the set of real numbers is uncountable, there exists a real number x such that all of the numbers $x + a_1, x + a_2, \ldots, x + a_n$ are irrational. ■

Solution 2. Let y be an irrational number such that for any $1 \leq m \leq n + 1$, at least one of the numbers $my + a_1, my + a_2, \ldots, my + a_n$ is rational. By the pigeonhole principle, there exists $1 \leq r \leq n$ such that at least two of the numbers $iy + a_r, jy + a_r$ are rational for some $1 \leq i < j \leq n + 1$. Then y is rational, a contradiction. Hence, for any irrational number y, there exists $1 \leq m \leq n + 1$ such that all of the numbers $my + a_1, my + a_2, \ldots, my + a_n$ are irrational. ■

Exercise 3 (British Mathematical Olympiad Round 2 2025 P1)**.** Prove that if n is a positive integer, then $\frac{1}{n}$ can be expressed as a finite sum of reciprocals of different triangular numbers. (A **triangular number** is an integer which is equal to $\frac{k(k+1)}{2}$ for some positive integer k.)

Walkthrough —

(a) Note that it suffices to express $\frac{1}{2n}$ as a finite sum of reciprocal of consecutive integers.

(b) Observe that

$$\frac{1}{2n} = \frac{1}{n} - \frac{1}{2n}$$

holds.

Solution 3. Note that

$$\frac{1}{2n} = \left(\frac{1}{n} - \frac{1}{n+1}\right) + \left(\frac{1}{n+1} - \frac{1}{n+2}\right) + \cdots + \left(\frac{1}{2n+1} - \frac{1}{2n}\right)$$

holds. This yields that $\frac{1}{n}$ is the sum of the reciprocals of

$$\frac{n(n+1)}{2}, \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2}, \ldots, \frac{(2n+1)2n}{2},$$

which are distinct triangular numbers since the map $x \mapsto \frac{x(x+1)}{2}$ from $\mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ is injective. ■

Exercise 4 (Brazil National Olympiad 2020 Level 3 P1,). Prove that there are positive integers $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_{2020}$ such that

$$\frac{1}{a_1} + \frac{1}{2a_2} + \frac{1}{3a_3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{2020a_{2020}} = 1.$$

Walkthrough —

(a) Show that for any positive integer n, there exist positive integers $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n$ such that

$$\frac{1}{a_1} + \frac{1}{2a_2} + \frac{1}{3a_3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{na_n} = 1.$$

(b) Observe that $1 = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2}$, $1 = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{6}$, $1 = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{12}$ etc. hold.

(c) Also note that

$$\frac{1}{n} = \frac{1}{n+1} + \frac{1}{n(n+1)}.$$

Solution 4. We claim that for any positive integer n, there exist positive integers $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n$ such that

$$\frac{1}{a_1} + \frac{1}{2a_2} + \frac{1}{3a_3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{na_n} = 1.$$

We will prove this claim by induction on n. The base case $n = 1$ is trivial, since we can take $a_1 = 1$. Also note that the case $n = 2$ holds, since we can take $a_1 = 2$ and $a_2 = 1$. Assume now that the claim holds for some $n \geq 2$. Hence, there exist positive integers $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n$ such that

$$\frac{1}{a_1} + \frac{1}{2a_2} + \frac{1}{3a_3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{na_n} = 1.$$

Using

$$\frac{1}{n} = \frac{1}{n+1} + \frac{1}{n(n+1)},$$

we obtain

$$\begin{aligned} 1 &= \frac{1}{a_1} + \frac{1}{2a_2} + \frac{1}{3a_3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{na_n} \\ &= \frac{1}{a_1} + \frac{1}{2a_2} + \frac{1}{3a_3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{n(n+1)a_n} + \frac{1}{(n+1)a_n}. \end{aligned}$$

This shows that the claim also holds for $n+1$. By the principle of mathematical induction, the claim holds for all positive integers n. In particular, the claim holds for $n = 2020$, which completes the proof. ■

The content posted here and at this blog by Evan Chen are quite useful.

Solution 5. Note that

$$\frac{1}{1\cdot 2}+\frac{1}{2\cdot 3}+\cdots+\frac{1}{n(n+1)}=1-\frac{1}{n+1}$$

holds for all positive integers n. Taking

$$a_1=n+1, a_2=1, a_3=2, \ldots, a_{n+1}=n$$

yields

$$\frac{1}{a_1}+\frac{1}{2a_2}+\frac{1}{3a_3}+\cdots+\frac{1}{(n+1)a_{n+1}}=1.$$

■

Exercise 5 (Putnam 2009 B1,). Show that every positive rational number can be written as a quotient of products of factorials of (not necessarily distinct) primes. For example,

$$\frac{10}{9}=\frac{2!\cdot 5!}{3!\cdot 3!\cdot 3!}.$$

Example 6. Let $n\geq 2$ be an integer. Let m be the largest integer which is less than or equal to n, and which is a power of 2. Put ℓ_n = the least common multiple of $1,2,\ldots,n$. Show that l_n/m is odd, and that for every integer $k\leq n, k\neq m, l_n/k$ is even. Hence prove that

$$1+\frac{1}{2}+\cdots+\frac{1}{n}$$

is not an integer.

Exercise 7 (Moscow Math Circles). Does there exist irrational numbers x, y with $x>0$ such that x^y is rational?

Summary — Consider $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$.

Walkthrough —

(a) Consider $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$.

(b) If $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$ is rational, then we are done by taking $x=y=\sqrt{2}$.

(c) If $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$ is irrational, then can you find out suitable x, y?

Solution 6. Consider $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$. If $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$ is rational, then we may take $x=y=\sqrt{2}$. If $\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$ is irrational, then taking $x=\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}$ and $y=\sqrt{2}$, we find that

$$x^y=\left(\sqrt{2}^{\sqrt{2}}\right)^{\sqrt{2}}=\left(\sqrt{2}\right)^2=2,$$

which is a rational number. ■

Exercise 8 (All-Russian Mathematical Olympiad 1989, , N. Agahanov)**.** [Sli97, p. 14]

1. Do there exist real numbers a and b such that $a+b$ is rational and a^n+b^n is irrational for each natural number $n \geq 2$?
2. Do there exist real numbers a and b such that $a+b$ is irrational and a^n+b^n is rational for each natural number $n \geq 2$?

Walkthrough —

(a) For the first part, take $a = 1+\sqrt{2}$. Can one come up with a suitable b?

(b) For the second part, show that a^2b^2 is a nonzero rational number. Considering the difference

$$(a^5+b^5)-(a^2+b^2)(a^3+b^3)$$

could be useful.

Solution 7. ■

Exercise 9 (All-Russian Mathematical Olympiad (District Stage) 2002 Grade 11 P1)**.** Let x, y be real number such that x^p+y^q is rational for any different odd primes p, q. Show that x and y are rational.

Solution 8. The given condition implies that for any three distinct primes p, q, r,

$$x^p - x^q, x^q - x^r$$

are rational since

$$x^p - x^q = \left(x^p+y^r\right) - \left(x^q+y^r\right), x^q - x^r = \left(x^q+y^p\right) - \left(x^r+y^p\right).$$

It follows that

$$a = x^7 - x^5, b = x^5 - x^3$$

are rational. If $b = 0$, then $x = 0$ or $x = \pm 1$, and hence x is rational. If $b \neq 0$, then note that $x^2 = \frac{a}{b}$, which shows that x^2 is rational. Observing that

$$b = x^2(x^2-1)x,$$

it follows that if $b \neq 0$, then x is rational. The rationality of y follows similarly. ■

Exercise 10 (RMO 2013d P4,)**.** Let x be a nonzero real number such that $x^4 + \frac{1}{x^4}$ and $x^5 + \frac{1}{x^5}$ are both rational numbers. Prove that $x + \frac{1}{x}$ is a rational number.

Summary — Consider the difference

$$\left(x^5+\frac{1}{x^5}\right)-\left(x^4+\frac{1}{x^4}\right)\left(x+\frac{1}{x}\right).$$

Solution 9. For a positive integer n, put $y_n = x^n + \frac{1}{x^n}$. Note that

$$y_5 = y_1y_4 - y_3 = y_1y_4 - y_1(y_2 - 1) = y_1(y_4 - y_2 + 1),$$

and $y_4 - y_2 + 1$ is nonzero, otherwise, we would get $y_2^2 - y_2 - 1 = 0$, that is, $y_2 = \frac{1\pm\sqrt{5}}{2}$, which shows that $y_4 = \frac{3\pm\sqrt{5}}{2}$, which contradicts that y_4 is rational. To show that y_1 is rational, it suffices to show that y_2 is rational. Observe that

$$y_{10} = y_2y_8 - y_6 = y_2y_8 - y_2y_4 + y_2 = y_2(y_8 - y_4 + 1),$$

and $y_8 - y_4 + 1 \neq 0$ (otherwise, we would obtain $y_4^2 - y_4 - 1 = 0$, which contradicts the rationality of y_4). Since y_{10}, y_8, y_4 are rational, it follows that y_2 is rational. Using

$$y_5 = y_1(y_4 - y_2 + 1),$$

and that $y_4 - y_2 + 1$ is nonzero, we conclude that y_1 is rational. ■

Exercise 11 (British Mathematical Olympiad Round 1 2004/5 P5)**.** Let S be a set of rational numbers with the following properties:

1. $\frac{1}{2} \in S$,
2. If $x \in S$, then both $\frac{1}{x+1} \in S$ and $\frac{x}{x+1} \in S$.

Prove that S contains all rational numbers in the interval $0 < x < 1$.

Walkthrough —

(a) Since $\frac{1}{2}$ lies in S, by the second condition, it follows that $\frac{2}{3}$ lies in S and so does $\frac{1}{3}$.

(b) Taking $x = \frac{1}{3}$, it follows that

$$\frac{3}{4}, \frac{1}{4}$$

lie in S. **Note that we have showed that S contains all the rationals between 0 and 1 with denominator at most 4.**

(c) Taking $x = \frac{2}{3}$, it follows that

$$\frac{2}{5}, \frac{3}{5}$$

lie in S. We are **not in a position** to conclude that S contains all the rationals between 0 and 1 with denominator at most 5.

(d) Taking $x = \frac{1}{4}$, it follows that

$$\frac{1}{5}, \frac{4}{5}$$

lie in S. It follows that S contains all the rationals between 0 and 1 with denominator at most 5.

(e) Does the above provide any insight to conclude that S contains all the rationals between 0 and 1? For instance, can one expect the following (and then prove, or realize that it is false, or argue along different lines)?

> For a rational number x lying in S, the rationals
>
> $$\frac{1}{x+1}, \frac{x}{x+1}$$
>
> have denominators larger[a] than that of x.
>
> [a] Often, while being naive, one takes the liberty to write **larger** to mean **no smaller**, that is, **greater than or equal to**. But this is **NOT allowed** while writing down a solution.

Or, stated in a different way,

> A rational number lying in $(0,1)$ can be obtained from a rational number lying in $(0,1)$ with smaller denominator by applying one of the maps
>
> $$x \mapsto \frac{1}{x+1}, x \mapsto \frac{x}{x+1}.$$

Solution 10. It suffices to establish the following.

> **Claim —** For any integer $k \geq 2$, all the rationals lying in $(0,1)$ with denominators not exceeding k lie in S, that is, we have
>
> $$\left\{\frac{1}{\ell}, \frac{2}{\ell}, \ldots, \frac{\ell-2}{\ell}, \frac{\ell-1}{\ell}\right\} \subseteq S \quad \text{for all } 2 \leq \ell \leq k. \tag{1}$$

Proof of the Claim. Eq. (1) holds for $k = 2$ from condition (1). Suppose Eq. (1) holds for $k = n-1$ for some integer $n \geq 3$. Let m be an integer satisfying $1 \leq m < n$. Using the induction hypothesis, we will show that $\frac{m}{n}$ lies in S. Note that for $0 < x < 1$, the inequalities

$$0 < \frac{x}{x+1} < \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2} < \frac{1}{x+1} < 1$$

hold. Using Condition (1), it follows that $\frac{m}{n}$ lies in S if $\frac{m}{n} = \frac{1}{2}$. If $0 < \frac{m}{n} < \frac{1}{2}$, then

$$\frac{x}{x+1} = \frac{m}{n}$$

holds for $x = \frac{m}{n-m}$, which is a rational number lying in $(0,1)$ with denominator $\leq n-1$, and by induction hypothesis, the set S contains $\frac{m}{n}$. Moreover, if

$\frac{1}{2} < \frac{m}{n} < 1$, then

$$\frac{1}{x+1} = \frac{m}{n}$$

holds for $x = \frac{n-m}{m}$, which is a rational number lying in $(0,1)$ with denominator $\leq n-1$, and by induction hypothesis, the set S contains $\frac{m}{n}$. We conclude that for any integer $n \geq 3$, Eq. (1) holds for $k = n$ if it holds for $k = n-1$. □

■

Exercise 12 (Romania JBMO TST 1999 Day 1 P3,). Let S be a set of rational numbers with the following properties:

1. $\frac{1}{2} \in S$,
2. If $x \in S$, then both $\frac{x}{2} \in S$ and $\frac{1}{x+1} \in S$.

Prove that S contains all the rational numbers from the interval $(0,1)$.

Walkthrough —

(a) Taking $x = \frac{1}{2}$, it follows that S contains $\frac{2}{3}$, and hence it also contains $\frac{1}{3}$.

(b) Taking $x = \frac{1}{2}$, it follows that S contains $\frac{1}{4}$. Next, taking $x = \frac{1}{3}$, we obtain that S contains $\frac{3}{4}$.

(c) Applying the map $x \mapsto \frac{1}{x+1}$ to $x = \frac{2}{3}, \frac{1}{4}$, it follows that S contains $\frac{3}{5}, \frac{4}{5}$. Since S contains $\frac{4}{5}$, the set S also contains $\frac{2}{5}, \frac{1}{5}$.

(d) Applying $x \mapsto \frac{1}{x+1}$ to $x = \frac{1}{5}$, it follows that S contains $\frac{5}{6}$. Note that S contains $\frac{4}{6} = \frac{2}{3}, \frac{3}{6} = \frac{1}{2}, \frac{2}{6} = \frac{1}{3}$. It also follows that S contains $\frac{1}{6}$.

(e) Does the above provide any insight into the problem? Can one expect the following?

> The rationals lying in $(\frac{1}{2}, 1)$ can be obtained by applying the map $x \mapsto \frac{1}{x+1}$ to the rationals lying in $(0,1)$ with small denominators. Moreover, a rational number r lying in $(0, \frac{1}{2})$ can be obtained by applying the map $x \mapsto \frac{x}{2}$ to the rationals lying in $(\frac{1}{2}, 1)$, more specifically, to those rationals with denominators at most the denominator of r.

Solution 11. It suffices to establish the following.

> **Claim** — For any integer $k \geq 2$, all the rationals lying in $(0,1)$ with

denominators not exceeding k lie in S, that is, we have

$$\left\{\frac{1}{\ell}, \frac{2}{\ell}, \ldots, \frac{\ell-2}{\ell}, \frac{\ell-1}{\ell}\right\} \subseteq S \quad \text{for all } 2 \leq \ell \leq k. \tag{2}$$

Proof of the Claim. Note that Eq. (2) holds for $k = 2$ by hypothesis. Suppose Eq. (2) holds for $k = n - 1$ where $n \geq 3$ is an integer. Let m be an integer satisfying $1 \leq m < n$. Using the induction hypothesis, we will show that $\frac{m}{n}$ lies in S. Note that for $0 < x < 1$, the inequalities

$$\frac{1}{2} < \frac{x}{x+1} < 1$$

hold. If $\frac{m}{n}$ is equal to $\frac{1}{2}$, then it lies in S by hypothesis. If $\frac{m}{n}$ lies in $(\frac{1}{2}, 1)$, then

$$\frac{1}{x+1} = \frac{m}{n}$$

holds for $x = \frac{n-m}{m}$, which is a rational number lying in $(0, 1)$ with denominator $\leq n - 1$, and by induction hypothesis, the set S contains $\frac{m}{n}$. If $\frac{m}{n}$ lies in $(0, \frac{1}{2})$, then the rational number $\frac{2m}{n}$ lies in $(\frac{1}{2}, 1)$, and if it has denominator $< n$ (when expressed in its least form), then it is an element of S by the induction hypothesis, and if it has denominator equal to n (when expressed in its least form), then by the above argument, it lies in S, and consequently, S contains $\frac{m}{n}$. We conclude that for any integer $n \geq 3$, Eq. (2) holds for $k = n$ if it holds for $k = n - 1$. □

■

Exercise 13 (Putnam 2009 A4,). Let S be a set of rational numbers such that

1. 0 lies in S,
2. If $x \in S$, then $x + 1 \in S$ and $x - 1 \in S$,
3. If $x \in S$ and $x \notin \{0, 1\}$, then $\frac{1}{x(x-1)}$ lies in S.

Must S contain all rational numbers?

Exercise 14 (RMO 2019a P1,). Suppose x is a nonzero real number such that both x^5 and $20x + \frac{19}{x}$ are rational numbers. Prove that x is a rational number.

Solution 12. Let us establish the following more general claim.

Claim — Let x be a nonzero real number and r be a rational number such that x^5 and $x+\frac{r}{x}$ are rational numbers. Then x is a rational number.

Proof of the Claim. Note that

$$x^2+\frac{r^2}{x^2}, x^3+\frac{r^3}{x^3}$$

are rational. Write $s=x^5$ and note that

$$x^3+\frac{r^3}{x^3}=\frac{r^3}{s}x^2+\frac{s}{x^2}.$$

It follows that there are rational numbers a, b such that

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & r^2 \\ \frac{r^3}{s} & s \end{pmatrix}\begin{pmatrix} x^2 \\ \frac{1}{x^2} \end{pmatrix}=\begin{pmatrix} a \\ b \end{pmatrix}$$

holds. If the determinant of $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & r^2 \\ \frac{r^3}{s} & s \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ is nonzero, then it follows that x^2 is rational, and using the rationality of x^5, we obtain that x is rational. If the determinant of $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & r^2 \\ \frac{r^3}{s} & s \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ is zero, then we get $s^2=r^5$, which implies that $x^{10}=r^5$, and hence, x^2 is rational, and consequently, so is x. □

■

References

[**Che25**] Evan Chen. *The OTIS Excerpts*. Available at https://web.evanchen.cc/excerpts.html. 2025, pp. vi+289 (cited p. 1)

[**Sli97**] A.M. Slinko. *USSR Mathematical Olympiads, 1989-1992*. Australian Mathematics Trust enrichment series. Australian Mathematics Trust, 1997. ISBN: 9780646336183. URL: https://books.google.de/books?id=OVlnomt12GQC (cited p. 6)